
AFP

US district court in March this year.

However, such accidents, arrests or indictments are no deterrent to the perilous aspirations of individuals from states such as Gujarat, Punjab and Haryana. Indeed, days after the Vatry incident, charter flights had been taking off almost every week from Dubai to destinations that allow visa-on-arrival for Indians, says Sanjay Kharat, superintendent of police, CID, who is heading the Vatry probe. "We understand the risks involved," says Rannaben, whose two sons and husband have embarked on the donkey or *'dunki'* route—a roundabout journey crafted to dodge border controls—multiple times in their lives. "Jagdishbhai's family's case was unfortunate, but for every such incident, thousands have successfully crossed over and become wealthy," she adds.

A pivotal motivation driving this mad rush is the transformation of family fortunes. No one exemplifies this better than Rannaben and her family. Her husband P.V. Patel reached the US in the mid-'90s with an alleged fake passport for Rs 35 lakh. He toiled for a decade at a 7-Eleven shop in New Jersey, followed by another seven years in the kitchens of various takeaway food joints. Rannaben and her sons moved out of their flat into a two-storey tenement within a gated community in Mehsana's city centre within five years of Patel's move to the US. Five years ago, as his return approached after he turned 60, the couple sent their elder son Rashesh to the US via the Canada border, at a cost of Rs 60 lakh. However, Rashesh did not have the same luck as his father; he spent 17 months in jail before being deported in 2022, with the family spending Rs 25 lakh on legal fees. In 2021, they managed to successfully send their younger son Ronak to Chicago via Africa and Mexico after three attempts spanning over four months. He is now "settled" in Chicago. Meanwhile, the family is preparing to send Rashesh back into the US again. "He will depart for Turkey next week," Rannaben says breezily, as she shifts the conversation to the heart of the matter—how she is busy shortlisting brides for her sons "settled" abroad. As is Radhaben, in her sixties, mother of 21-year-old Punit Patel who returned from Vatry. "We will find another agent soon. We are in a hurry as he is nearing marriageable age." Her elder son had ventured down the path of 'bey number' (illegal route) five years ago and has since attained legal status abroad. Radhaben hasn't given up hope for her second-born.

For a young immigrant, the hallmark of an elevated lifestyle is securing a Patidar bride followed by lavish weddings and a well-appointed home. Dozens of villages in north Gujarat are dotted with modern two- or three-storey bungalows, run by distant relatives or hired assistance. The landscape includes concrete streets and amenities such as schools and hospitals, though these resources remain largely underutilised due to the mass exodus. These settlements only burst with activity during the four winter months when the NRIs visit. The Rs 1-1.5 lakh per month that each member remits through covert Angadia and Hawala networks fuels purchases of expensive bikes, cars and gold ornaments, along with indulgences like cricket betting.

"GUJARATI ENTREPRENEURS FACILITATE CHEAP LABOUR. A GROUP OF THEM PAY IN ADVANCE TO HUMAN TRAFFICKERS FOR A FLIGHTLOAD OF LABOUR. THEY WORK IN MOTELS, EXPRESS STORES, CAFES ETC. UP TO 18 HOURS DAILY AND GET PAID 50 PER CENT OF THEIR DUE"

–RAJKUMAR PANDIAN *ADGP, CID-Crime and Railways*

THE PRICE OF THE 'PRIZE'

During the interrogation of around a dozen Vatry-returned passengers, the CID officers were astounded by a baffling revelation—the cost per person for a months-long one-way trip to enter the US via Canada or Mexico was Rs 70 lakh. Who funds these risky trips? "Local wealthy individuals invest in an aspirant with an expectation of getting a return on their investment in three years at a reasonable rate of interest," says Babubhai Patel, a veteran US citizen with business interests in India and the US. "They work for 10-12 hours a day for less than the minimum hourly labour rates. They share accommodation or sleep on the shop floor, incurring minimum costs, paying off loans and sending money home."

These well-oiled syndicates work on trust within the Gujarati communities, dominated by Patidars but not restricted to them. All payments are made to the agents through an opaque Hawala system. Many call it modern-day bonded labour, when, ironically, the labourers willingly offer to get trafficked and exploited by their employers. "Gujarati entrepreneurs facilitate cheap labour. A group of employers pay in advance to human traffickers for a flightload of labour," says Rajkumar Pandian, additional director general, CID-Crime and Railways. Survivors and entrepreneurs in the US reveal that